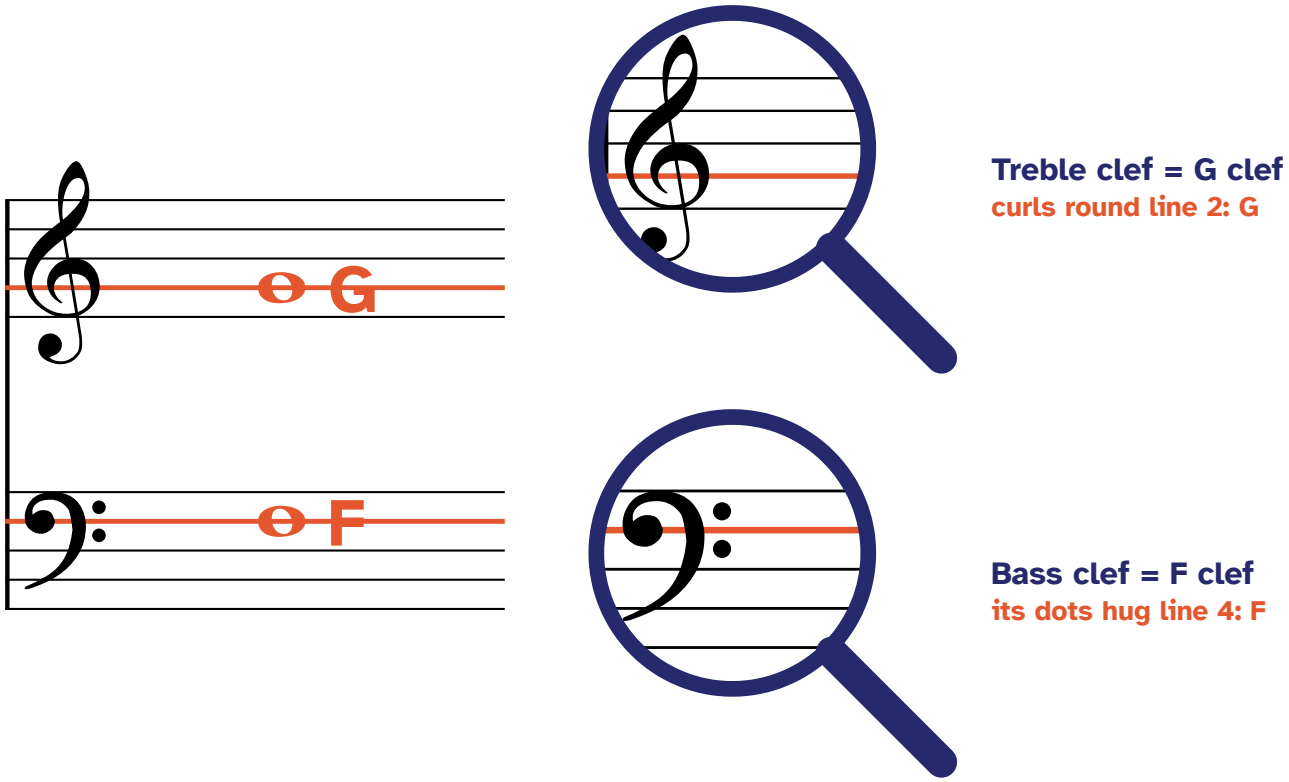
PART I · PITCH · 2

The staff and the clefs

Music is written on a **staff**: five lines and four spaces, counted from the **bottom**. Higher on the staff means higher on the keyboard. The **clef** at the start is the key to the code: it names one line, and every other note follows from it.

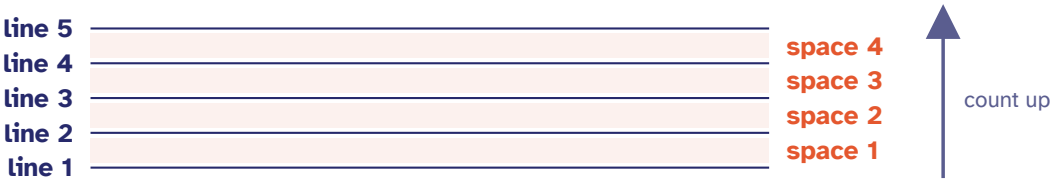
THE SECRET

The treble clef curls round G; the bass clef's two dots hug F.



The treble clef is the G clef: it curls round G · the bass clef is the F clef: its dots hug F

Five lines, four spaces

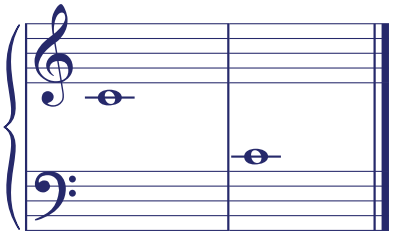


Always count from the **bottom**: line 1 is the lowest line, space 1 the lowest space.

PART I · PITCH · 2 · CONTINUED

The grand staff

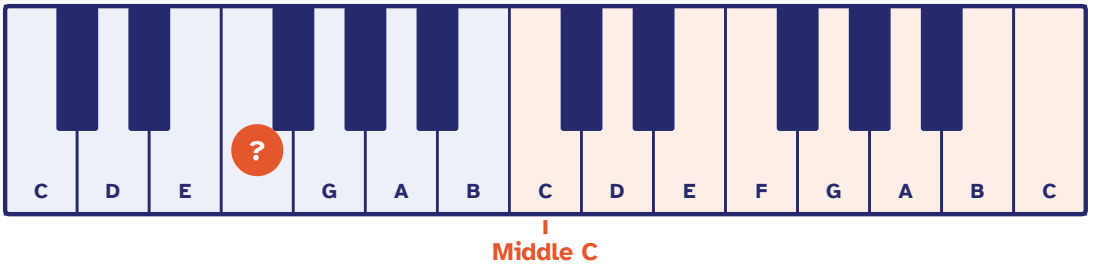
Two staves joined by a brace: the **treble** staff on top, usually for the right hand, and the **bass** staff below, usually for the left. **Middle C** sits between them on its own short line, in either staff.



Middle C in the treble staff (left) and in the bass staff (right): the same key.

EXAMPLE

Which staff is this key written on?
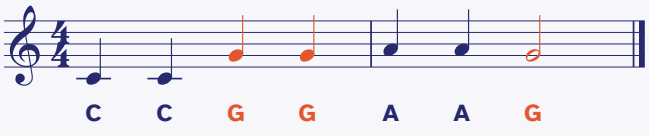


1. **Find Middle C.**
2. **Is the ? to its left or right?** Left is lower: the blue half.
3. **Low keys go on the bass staff**, high keys on the treble staff.

The **?** is below Middle C, so it is written on the **bass staff**, usually for the left hand.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



The treble clef curls round **line 2: G**, the very note Twinkle leaps up to. Read the round head, not the stem: the stem never changes the note.

Try it. Point to the G line, then play C C G G A A G.

THINK OF IT A clef is a pair of glasses: the same lines, read through a different pair.

TRAP

× Reading bass-clef notes as if they were treble: check the clef on every line.

SEE ALSO
The staff and the keyboard p. 29 · Reading the notes p. 32

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 2 · Online: The Staff & the Two Clefs